PHIL 360
TOPICS IN SOCIAL EPISTEMOLOGY

ANTONIO MARIA CLEANI

Overview

The practices by which we acquire and transmit knowledge are messy, interdependent, and deeply embedded in social structures. Coordinating action requires us to reconcile our beliefs with the beliefs of those around us. Because no one can investigate everything firsthand, we rely on experts, institutions, and distributed systems of inquiry. Our informational environments shape what we come to believe, and the incentives that govern those environments can amplify or distort the truth.

Social epistemology is the branch of epistemology that studies precisely these social dimensions of knowledge. This course takes a deep dive into contemporary social epistemology, with a focus on topics of political significance. These topics fall into five units:

Epistemic democracy: Can democratic decision making be justified as a means of tracking the truth? Under what conditions is a group more likely than any of its members to get things right, and when does aggregating individual judgments produce an inconsistent collective view?

Epistemic communities: How should a community of inquirers divide its cognitive labor? How does who communicates with whom affect what a community comes to believe? Is more communication always better? Can individual epistemic vices give rise to collective epistemic virtues?

Misinformation: How can interested parties, such as industry groups and propagandists, lead a community to false beliefs, often without ever lying? How can communities protect themselves against biased sources? When, if ever, is it reasonable to believe a conspiracy theory?

Polarization: What does it mean for a group to be polarized? How do different groups of people end up with radically different beliefs about the same topic? How does mistrust contribute to polarization? Can polarization ever be rational?

Standpoint epistemology: How does our social position affect what we are in a position to know? What wrong is done to someone when their testimony is discounted because of who they are? Do marginalized groups enjoy any epistemic advantage?

A feature tying these topics together is that they are all amenable to formal treatment. We will approach them through the lens of formal models, drawing especially

from probability theory and epistemic network models—computer simulations of communities of inquirers who learn from the world and from each other. Along the way, we will replicate some of the simulations from the readings and run our own. That said, the course is designed to be accessible independently of any prior mathematical or programming training. Technical material will be gently introduced from first principles and artificial intelligence tools will help us with programming. You will be able to choose between more formal and more informal assignments, depending on your interests and background.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this course, you will be able to:

- Understand and critically evaluate key theories, arguments, and concepts in contemporary social epistemology.
- Explain how formal models (jury theorems, models of judgment aggregation, and epistemic network models) represent real-world epistemic phenomena, and assess what their idealizations leave out.
- Solve technical exercises involving probability theory, judgment aggregation, and Bayesian learning in networks.
- Replicate, modify, and interpret simple computer simulations of epistemic communities.
- Connect results in social epistemology to debates in political philosophy, philosophy of science, and feminist epistemology, and apply them to novel problems and scenarios.
- Produce argumentative essays that engage with contemporary literature in social epistemology.

Assessment

Description of Assignments. You will be assessed through a combination of Perusall annotations, unit-specific take-home assignments, two short papers, a final term paper extending one of your short papers, and participation. Each of these components is described in more detail below.

Perusall Readings. Perusall is a collaborative active reading platform that allows you to publicly annotate the readings and engage in discussions with your classmates. Each week, you will be asked to read the assigned materials and make at least two substantive annotations. Substantive annotations include questions, comments, objections, and connections to other materials. You can choose to either annotate the text directly or respond to your classmates' annotations. Perusall annotations are automatically graded by the platform.

Take-Home Assignments. At the beginning of each week I will release one take-home assignment. Each will be either a *problem set* or an *quiz*.

- *Problem sets* will consist of exercises that test your understanding of the more technical material covered in the lectures and readings and/or your

ability to apply it to real-world phenomena. Some formal problem sets will consist of programming tasks (mostly in python). If you don't know any programming, don't worry: you'll be able to use artificial intelligence tools as coding assistants.

- *Quizzes* will consist of short essay questions. While you will still need to some grasp of technical material to complete quizzes, the questions will focus on the philosophical interpretations of formal models and the results obtained through them, rather than on the inner working of the models themselves.

You must choose and complete one take-home assignment per unit, for a total of five assignments throughout the semester. At least one of these must be a formal problem set, though I recommend doing at least three problem sets to get the most out of this course.

Short Papers. You will be asked to submit two short papers throughout the semester, each of approximately 1,500 words. Each short paper should be about a different topic, and the topics should come from different units. Each short paper is due three days after the unit covering the relevant topic is completed.

A selection of prompts will be provided, and you will be able to choose between informal and formally oriented prompts. You are also welcome to propose your own question, though you will need to get my approval before proceeding.

Final Term Paper. The final term paper will be due at the end of the semester and should be approximately 3000 words. Your final term paper should be an extension of one of your short papers. You will be expected to take into account any feedback you receive on the short paper and to expand on the ideas presented in it. Final papers are due on [date].

Participation. You are expected to regularly show up to class and demonstrate active engagement. One way to demonstrate active engagement is by asking questions during lectures and contributing to in-class discussion. But not everybody feels comfortable speaking up in class, and that is perfectly fine. You can also demonstrate active engagement by being particularly active on Perusall (regularly submitting more than two annotations per reading), reaching out to me with questions or comments via email, or attending office hours. I encourage you to show up to office hours at least once during the semester, even if you don't have any specific questions.

Grade Breakdown. Your preliminary grade will be computed as a weighted average of the following components:

- Perusall annotations: 10%
- Take-home assignments: 40% (12% each)
- Short papers: 30%
- Final term paper: 15%
- Participation: 5%

Each component will be graded on a 100-point scale, and your final letter grade will be assigned according to the following scale:

Numerical Range	**Letter Grade**
95-100	A
90-94	A-
87-89	B+
84-86	B
80-83	B-
77-79	C+
74-76	C
70-73	C-
60-69	D
0-59	F

Course Policies

Readings. I expect you to do the readings and post your Perusall annotations before our second meeting the week they are assigned. This will allow you to get the most out of our lectures and discussions.

The readings can get challenging. I do not expect you to understand and remember every single detail of every single reading. What I do expect is that you make a good-faith effort to engage with the material and, if you do get confused, try to make productive use of your confusion. Getting confused is a natural part of the learning process. Being able to comfortably sit with confusion and use it as a springboard for further inquiry are important skills to develop. If you find yourself getting confused, try to get clear on what exactly is confusing you and share it with others. And if something confuses you, chances are that it is also confusing other people. So sharing your confusion (e.g., as a Perusall annotation or in class) can be a great way to spark discussion and help everyone get clearer on the material.

Some of the readings will be more technical than others. I have designed every unit so that at least one of the papers in it is non-technical. In addition, I have done my best to select technical readings that can be understood without needing to grasp *every* technical detail. For example, many of the readings present their main philosophical contributions informally in the main text, while relegating the technical details to appendices. When appropriate, I will post supplementary lecture notes that provide gentler introductions to the technical material in the readings. You can read these either in place of technical appendices or as preliminary material in addition to them, depending on your interests and background.

Collaboration. I encourage you to collaborate with your classmates, within limits. For each take-home assignment, you can choose whether to work individually or in a group of up to three students. If you choose to collaborate, you can work on the exercises or quiz questions with your group, but

(1) You must work together on the same type of assignment (i.e., either the problem set or the quiz).

(2) You cannot be a member of more than one group, and you must not discuss or share your solutions with anyone outside your group;

(3) You must write up your solutions independently and in your own words, mentioning the other members of your group in your submission.

Your collaboration group is not fixed once and for all. You can choose to work with different people on different assignments, and you can also choose to work individually on some assignments and in a group on others.

All members of a group should contribute meaningfully to each question in the take-home assignment to the best of their abilities. Working together on a three-question take-home assignment in a group of three does not mean doing one exercise each independently and then pooling together your solutions. Take-home assignments will be designed to be cumulative, with later questions building on earlier ones, to encourage you to work through the entire assignment together.

For short papers and the final term paper, you are encouraged to discuss the prompts and share ideas with anyone else in the class. However, you must write up your papers independently and not share your written work with anyone else.

Late Submissions. I have tried to design assessment for this class in a way that minimizes the chances you will need to ask for extensions. You only need to submit one assignment per unit and two short papers throughout the semester, so you have some flexibility in managing your workload.

But I understand that even with proper planning, life can get in the way. To accommodate that, everybody gets 7 free extension days that they can use for any assignment *except for the final paper*, no questions asked. You don't need to tell me when you're using your extension days: Brightspace will keep track of that for you. You can use as many extension days as you want on a single assignment, but once you run out of extension days you are not getting any extra ones, so save them for when you really need them.

Late submissions not covered by free extension days will be penalized by a deduction of 5 percentage points per day. For example, if you submit an assignment that would have received a grade of 85 two days late without using any extension days, your grade for that assignment will be 75.

Communication. The best way to get in touch with me outside of class and office hours is via email. I will do my best to respond to your emails within 24 hours during the week and within 48 hours on weekends. When writing to me, please include PHIL360 in the subject line.

Artificial Intelligence. This course will make use of computer simulations to test philosophical hypotheses, but it is not a programming course. You are not expected to have any prior programming experience, nor to learn programming in order to succeed. If you're not confident in your programming skills, you are more than welcome to use artificial intelligence tools as code assistants. Problem sets that involve programming tasks will come with explicit instructions on what the limits of permissible AI assistance are. Generally speaking, it's okay to have AI generate the code for a simulation that you want to run, provided you do the conceptual

work required in designing the simulation yourself: what situation are you trying to model? What hypothesis are you testing? What happens during each round of the simulation? When you use AI-generated code in your assignments, you should attach screenshots of the conversation you had with the models that shows you did in fact do this conceptual work yourself.

When it comes to using AI for doing *philosophy*, the rules are stricter. As a rule of thumb, you are permitted to use generative AI tools to assist with brainstorming, ask clarificatory questions, and providing feedback on your *own* ideas. You are *not* permitted to use generative AI tools to generate entirely new ideas for you, nor write or edit drafts for you.

When you ask for clarifications or feedback, each question you ask the model should show that *you've made an independent effort to answer the question on your own*, before asking the model for help. For example, you are not allowed to ask:

> Explain to me the definition of concept X.

Instead, ask:

> I'm a little confused about what this part of the definition of concept X means. My best guess is that it means this, because of such and so reasons. Do you think I'm on the right track?

This questions shows that you made an independent effort to understand the definition and you're sharing your results with the AI. The AI is then helping you think through ideas that are ultimately your own.

Similarly, you are not allowed to ask:

> Give me an argument for thesis X.

Instead, ask:

> Here's my argument for thesis X. I'm a bit unsure whether premise P is too strong. What are some ways of weakening it?

Again, here you are giving a model a starting point based on your own ideas. The model then helps you build on these ideas.

Likewise, don't ask:

> Solve this exercise for me.

Instead, ask:

> Here's my best attempt at solving this exercise. I'm kinda stuck at step 5. I'm thinking I should attack it by doing X, because of such and such reasons. Do you think this is a good way to go about it?

If you choose to use AI, you must export and submit your conversations with the model alongside your written submission. In your writing, you must reference these conversations the way you would reference any other source. Use footnotes

to indicate which conversation you are referencing. Using an AI tool to generate content without proper attribution will be treated as plagiarism and reported to the Office of Academic Integrity.

You should also be aware that AI tools may present incorrect or incomplete information. It is your responsibility to double check AI answers against traditional sources. You will be responsible for any errors or omissions made by the tool.

Course Materials

Course materials consist of a combination of journal articles and supplementary lecture notes. All required reading will be made available on Perusall, and supplementary lecture notes will be posted on Brightspace.

Course Schedule

Week	Topic	Readings
Introduction		
Week 0	Epistemic Dependence	Hardwig [1985] *Background:* Goldman [1999]; O'Connor et al. [2024]
Epistemic Democracy		
Week 1	Democracy as Inquiry	Anderson [2006] *Optional:* Singer [2018]
Week 2	The Discursive Dilemma	Pettit [2001] *Background:* List [2012] *Optional:* List and Pettit [2002]
Week 3	Jury Theorems	Dietrich and Spiekermann [2019] *Optional:* List and Goodin [2001]
Epistemic Communities		
Week 4	The Division of Cognitive Labor	Kitcher [1990] *Optional:* Zollman [2018]
Week 5	Communication Structure	Zollman [2007] *Background:* Zollman [2013] *Optional:* Zollman [2010]; Rosenstock et al. [2017]
Week 6	Mandevillian Intelligence	Smart [2018] *Optional:* Mayo-Wilson et al. [2011]
Misinformation		
Week 7	Propaganda	Weatherall et al. [2020] *Background:* Weatherall and O'Connor [2024] *Optional:* Mohseni et al. [2022]
Week 8	Biased Agents	Holman and Bruner [2015] *Optional:* Holman and Bruner [2017]

Week	Topic	Readings
Week 9	Conspiracy Theories	Keeley [1999] *Optional:* Poth and Dolega [2023]
Spring Break	No class	
Polarization		
Week 11	What Is Polarization?	Bramson et al. [2017] *Optional:* Nguyen [2020]
Week 12	Mistrust	O'Connor and Weatherall [2018] *Optional:* Weatherall and O'Connor [2020]; Weatherall and O'Connor [2021]
Week 13	Rational Polarization	Dorst [2023] (selections) *Optional:* Kelly [2008]; Singer et al. [2019]
Standpoint Epistemology		
Week 14	Testimonial Injustice	Fricker [2007], ch. 1 *Optional:* Pohlhaus [2012]
Week 15	Epistemic Advantage	Dror [2023] *Background:* Toole [2021]
Week 16	Standpoints in Networks	Wu [2023] *Optional:* O'Connor et al. [2019]; Fazelpour and Steel [2022]
Study Days	No class	
Finals Week	No class	

Statement on University Academic and Support Systems

Students and Disability Accommodations. USC welcomes students with disabilities into all of the University's educational programs. The Office of Student Accessibility Services (OSAS) is responsible for the determination of appropriate accommodations for students who encounter disability-related barriers. Once a student has completed the OSAS process (registration, initial appointment, and submitted documentation) and accommodations are determined to be reasonable and appropriate, a Letter of Accommodation (LOA) will be available to generate for each course. The LOA must be given to each course instructor by the student and followed up with a discussion. This should be done as early in the semester as possible as accommodations are not retroactive. More information can be found at osas.usc.edu. You may contact OSAS at (213) 740-0776 or via email at osasfrontdesk@usc.edu.

Student Financial Aid and Satisfactory Academic Progress. To be eligible for certain kinds of financial aid, students are required to maintain Satisfactory Academic Progress (SAP) toward their degree objectives. Visit the Financial Aid Office webpage for undergraduate- and graduate-level SAP eligibility requirements and the appeals process.

Support Systems.

Counseling and Mental Health. (213) 740-9355, 24/7 on call.
Free and confidential mental health treatment for students, including short-term psychotherapy, group counseling, stress fitness workshops, and crisis intervention.

988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline. 988 for both calls and text messages, 24/7 on call.
The 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline (formerly known as the National Suicide Prevention Lifeline) provides free and confidential emotional support to people in suicidal crisis or emotional distress 24 hours a day, 7 days a week, across the United States. The Lifeline consists of a national network of over 200 local crisis centers, combining custom local care and resources with national standards and best practices. The new, shorter phone number makes it easier for people to remember and access mental health crisis services (though the previous 1 (800) 273-8255 number will continue to function indefinitely) and represents a continued commitment to those in crisis.

CARE-SC: Confidential Advocacy, Resources, and Education Support Center. (213) 740-9355 (WELL), 24/7/365 on call.
Confidential advocates, prevention educators, and professional counseling teams work to promote a universal culture of consent, and prevent and respond to gender- and power-based harm. Services available to all USC students at no cost.

Office of Civil Rights Compliance. (213) 740-5086.
Information about how to get help or help someone affected by harassment, discrimination, retaliation on the basis of a protected characteristic, rights of protected classes, reporting options, and additional resources for students, faculty, staff, visitors, and applicants.

USC Campus Support and Intervention. (213) 740-0411, uscsupport@usc.edu.
Assists students and families in resolving complex personal, financial, and academic issues adversely affecting their success as a student.

USC Emergency Information. Latest updates regarding safety, including ways in which instruction will be continued if an officially declared emergency makes travel to campus infeasible.

USC Department of Public Safety. For 24 hour emergency assistance or to report a crime: UPC: (213) 740-4321, HSC: (323) 442-1000.
For 24 hour non-emergency assistance or information: UPC: (213) 740-6000, HSC: (323) 442-1200.

Office of the Ombuds. (213) 821-9556 (UPC) / (323) 442-0382 (HSC).
A safe and confidential place to share your USC-related issues with a University Ombuds who will work with you to explore options or paths to manage your concern.

Occupational Therapy Faculty Practice. (323) 442-2850 or otfp@med.usc.edu.
Lifestyle Redesign services for USC students to support health promoting habits and routines that enhance quality of life and academic performance.

The Office of Sustainability. The Office of Sustainability promotes numerous ways for all Trojans to study, work, and live sustainably at USC. Students can access tools, resources, and opportunities on their website and in the Sustainability Hub in the Student Union Building, Suite 101.

USC Report & Response. USC Report and Response provides a front door to reporting concerns, including an ability to report anonymously, which violate university policies or go against our Unifying Values and helps connect you with the support you need. The website provides a list of confidential resources, supporting offices, and policies that are available to our university community. The Resources page includes information regarding the university's response in the event of immigration enforcement activity on campus or involving a student or employee. Additional questions may be directed to the Office of Professionalism and Ethics (OPE) and ope@usc.edu or in reviewing the Office of Professionalism and Ethics website.